



Soviet infantry fight amid the ruined buildings of Stalingrad. German defeat in the city was a decisive turning point in World War II.



Naval power
US Navy dive-bombers fly over Midway Island in the Pacific. This was the location of a decisive duel between American and Japanese aircraft carriers in June 1942.

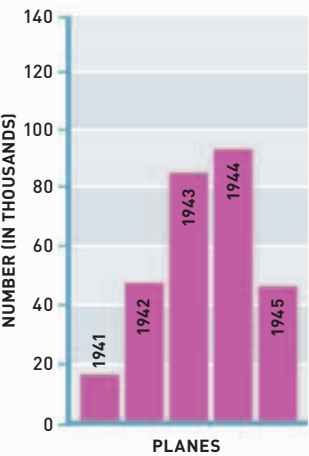
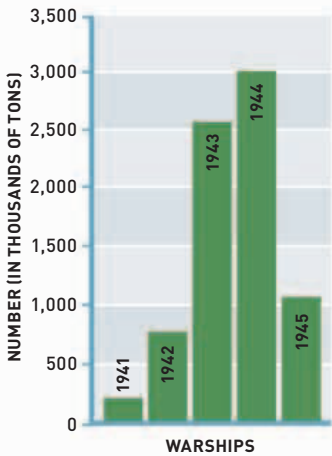
In the **desert war in North Africa**, after suffering repeated defeats at the hands of Field Marshal Erwin Rommel (1891–1944), the British Eighth Army, commanded by General Bernard Montgomery (1887–1976), won a great offensive victory at **Alamein** in October–November. As Rommel’s Axis army retreated westward across Libya, Allied forces, including a large contingent of American troops commanded by General Dwight D. Eisenhower (1890–1969), landed in French North Africa during

Operation Torch. Opposition from French colonial forces loyal to the Vichy government (see 1940) was easily overcome, leaving Rommel trapped between armies to his east and west. The Germans responded by extending their military occupation of France to the Vichy-ruled area. The war being fought in the **Soviet Union** (see 1941) came to its climactic turning point at the **Battle of Stalingrad**. The eastward advance of Axis forces had continued through most of the year, reaching the Caucasus by July and threatening the vital oilfields of Azerbaijan. Hitler insisted his troops capture



Yank tank
American-built Grant tanks were supplied to the British in North Africa. This one was used by General Montgomery as an observation post.

the city of Stalingrad—of symbolic importance because of its name. German soldiers entered the city in September, but the Soviets defended it street-by-street amid the ruined buildings. In November, Soviet General Georgi Zhukov (1896–1974) masterminded a counterattack. Striking from north and south, his armies encircled the Axis forces, trapping a quarter of a million men inside Stalingrad. Ordered by Hitler to stay and fight, by the end of the year they were starving, freezing, and short of ammunition. The German commander, Field Marshal Friedrich Paulus, was among the 90,000 men who lived to surrender the following February—and one of only a handful who then survived Soviet imprisonment.



American industrial miracle
The output of US factories and shipyards soared during World War II. The number of workers employed in shipbuilding alone rose from around 100,000 in 1940 to 1.7 million late in the war.

